

Technical Report Writing (TRW)

**Chapters No 16
Proposals**

Chapter in a Nutshell

- What is a proposal
- The external proposal
- The internal proposal

What is a proposal

A proposal is a document which is written to persuade the reader to accept the writer's idea. There are two kinds of proposals:

1. The external proposal
2. The internal proposal

The external proposal

In an external proposal, one firm responds to a request from another firm or the government, for a solution to a problem. Ranging from lengthy 100 pages or more to short 4 or 5 pages these documents secure contracts for firms. In simple words, a firm writes external proposals to win contracts for work, which can be both for commercial purpose and for obtaining funds for educational institutions like universities. Government agencies and large and small corporations issue a 'request for proposal' (RFP) which explains the project and lists its specifications precisely. The companies that receive the RFP write proposals to show how they will develop the project. After receiving all the proposals, the firm that requested them sends them to a team of evaluators, who rate these proposals to select the best overall proposal.

An external proposal has four main parts; executive summary, technical section, managerial section and financial section.

Executive summary. It is the summary of the contents of the three sections of the proposal in the light of chapter 6 and it is written last after the completion of the proposal.

Technical section. It begins by stating the problem or need to be solved (expressed in the RFP sent by the company which wants some project). Clearly demonstrate that the proposers understand what the customer expects. Describe the approach to solving the problem, within the maximum cost. Also describe alternative ways of solving the problems if any.

Management section. It describes the personnel, who will work directly on the project and explains their expertise, even qualifications of the personnel may be explained. Similarly, explain your firm's success with similar projects and willingness to provide technical assistance and training to their employees.

Financial section. It provides a breakdown of the costs for every item in the proposal. Often a brief introduction and table may be sufficient, but if the writer wants, details may be added.

The internal proposal. It is an in-house or intra-organizational document, where the writer urges or persuades someone/audience/reader in the same organization/firm to accept the idea of the writer or to fund equipment purchase or research. Being an in-house document, internal proposal tends to be treated as an informal document and can be written in the format of a memorandum/memo report.

Design of the proposal. An appropriate format should be selected (either formal or informal) A formal proposal has a title page, table of contents and summary and a formal format is needed in case of an external proposal, because it is from one firm to another. An informal proposal can be a memo report, which means, it can be written in the format of a memorandum, because it is an in-house proposal or internal proposal. Similarly all points of technical writing, discussed in chapter 4 should be taken care of.